

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

10 September 2005

To the friends gathered on the occasion of the Centenary of the Faith in Germany

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

¹ It is with jubilant hearts and feelings of deep gratitude that we greet all of you who have gathered to celebrate the one hundredth anniversary of the Faith of Bahá'u'lláh in Germany. No other community in the Western world can claim to have demonstrated a greater resilience in the face of formidable obstacles that threatened to rob you of the shining triumph, the potent prospects, signalized by your very meeting on so auspicious an occasion.

² The spark lit in Stuttgart with the arrival in 1905 of Dr. Edwin Fischer, which was fanned into a flame with the momentous visit of the beloved Master to that city eight years later, has burgeoned into a conflagration that bids fair to enkindle the hearts of troop after troop of your spiritually hungry, fellow citizens. Especially is this evident in the dynamic efforts currently afoot to intensify the expansion and consolidation process at the crux of the Five Year Plan.

³ This is a moment for reflection, profound reflection—one that recounts the highlights in contrast to the dark aspects punctuating the history of crisis and victory that depicts the evolution of the German community. It should enable you to appreciate more fully than before the outstanding results of the early believers' trust in Bahá'u'lláh and His unfailing guidance, which emboldened them to persevere despite the persecution they suffered and the prohibitions inflicted on their efforts. Their exemplary conduct assured the community of the capacity to rise like a phoenix from the devastation of the Second World War and thenceforward to become vibrant collaborators with their sister communities in prosecuting the great tasks set by the Divine Plan. How brilliantly do the signs of their success shine! Suffice it to mention a few: the erection on German soil of the first European House of Worship; the legal recognition accorded by the highest court in the land to the Cause of Bahá'u'lláh, underscoring the equality of its status to that enjoyed by other major religions; the wealth of Bahá'í literature translated and published in German; and the dispatch of pioneers to goal countries. Among these distinctions was the emergence of distinguished believers, including two Hands of the Cause of God whose tireless endeavours galvanized the will of the community to accomplish such wonderful feats.

⁴ Reflection, too, on the challenges and portents of the present hour is called for, since the remaining months of the current Plan are fleeting fast. This exercise is necessary to ensure that the two essential movements of the Plan are more widely, more consistently pursued, so that in the end the stalwart German community will stand stronger than ever, the better to realize the possibilities of the new Plan to be launched at Ridván 2006.

⁵ We are confident that at this stage in the perils of humankind that accompany the evolution of the Lesser Peace, the dearly loved occupants of the mighty stronghold of the

Cause in Germany will seize the opportunities open to them to move resolutely to the next chapter of their destiny which is unfolding so brilliantly. May they ever be spurred on by the unforgettable words of encouragement addressed to them by Shoghi Effendi when at an earlier stage in their struggles they faced a fateful moment:

6 My heart is filled with gratitude for the manifold evidences of the tenacity of faith, the collective efforts, the consolidated unity, the administrative accomplishments and the spiritual fervour so strikingly displayed by its members. 'Abdu'l-Bahá, whose special care, love and solicitude for the followers of Bahá'u'lláh in that promising country, most of you have recognized and no doubt still remember, is truly proud of your accomplishments and is well-pleased with the spirit that so powerfully animates you in His service. His spirit will continue to overshadow you in your labours and to sustain and guide you in your exertions. Persevere and be confident.

7 With deep love, we enfold you all in our fervent supplications at the Holy Threshold.

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]